Chapter Thirty-Eight

South of India

Between 1215 and 1283,
Sri Lanka is divided between Hindu and Buddhist kings,
and the Pandyas of the south bring an end to the Chola empire

In 1215, the Hindu nobleman Magha fled south, along the eastern coast of India. The sultan of Delhi was bearing down on him from the north; so he left his lands in Orissa and, followed by his own private army, set out to find a new country.

Orissa, now ruled by a string of powerful Hindu kings descended from Chola royalty, was not a place where an ambitious soldier could establish his own power. Nor was the kingdom of Chola, directly south of it, shrunken from its twelfth-century height but still strong. Magha kept going south, crossing over the Palk Strait, and came to the shores of Sri Lanka.

Parakrama Bahu's carefully constructed kingdom, well watered and prosperous, held together by the net of state-sponsored Buddhism, lay open to invasion. Three years earlier, a newcomer from the south of India had arrived and taken the throne for himself; a Buddhist newcomer who, although a foreign invader, ruled (in the words of the *Culavamsa*, the chronicle of kings written in Sri Lanka's Pali language) "without transgressing." But he could not raise enough support to fight back against Magha, who had swelled his